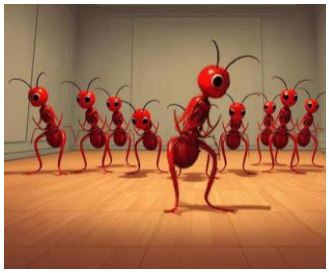
The Elaborate Gift



"Isaac! You must find out!"

"Mary, would it not be better if we waited for Father to return, as we always do?" I responded gently. "Besides, I doubt if I could find out what he's getting."

"I want to know now!" wailed Hannah.

Every year Father would bring home an elaborate gift for the twins on their birthday. Last year, it was an army of penguins carrying in plates of biscuits, each biscuit making faces at Mary and Hannah. And two years ago, giant white mice brought in plates of cherry tarts, with each tart making rude noises.

"You can do anything, Isaac," said Mary. "Go and find out what Father is up to this year."

With a sigh and considerable doubts, I went off into the night, towards a large department store that I knew Father often frequented. To my surprise, I had little trouble locating a cavernous room with a figure in a great coat talking with a large ant of equal stature, perhaps a queen, and many more ants behind her. From this distance I could not make out whether the figure was the object of my search, and I dare not get closer for fear of being detected.

He was having difficulty communicating with the ant. She seemed unwilling to make eye contact and would frequently turn away and shuffle her feet, at which point all the ants behind her did the same. The figure grew frustrated and pointed to a group of ants behind him at attention – soldier ants, I supposed. At last, the transaction seemed to be completed. The figure opened a box and produced several pies, which he distributed to the soldiers. As soon as the pies reached their appointed positions, they started jeering at anyone around them. I very much wanted to get a better look at the figure, but it was clearly necessary that I leave immediately. At any moment, he might break off and head towards the exit where I would be discovered.

When I reached home, Mary could barely contain herself. "What did you find out?"

"I bet it's cakes!" exclaimed Hannah. "Brought in by some animals!"

I had to confess that I was not sure. I hadn't gotten a good look at the main actor in the drama.

"Oh, Isaac! I'm sure you know. You can do everything! Tell us!" cried Mary.

"Is it cakes?" asked Hannah.

I had a much lower assessment of my abilities in this regard and responded carefully. "I'm not sure, but if I have seen Father, it is pies taunting on the soldiers of shy ants."